THE WARS OF *History*

bly different from the days preceding the Babri demolition, where BJP luminaries were the field marshals leading from the front. The shades of gradation in Hindutva colours help in a division of labour now. Party president J.P. Nadda said this week that issues like Gyanvapi are "decided by the court *and* the Constitution; the BJP implements it in letter and spirit". The top leadership has directed that the party speak only of Kashi and Mathura, not dilute things with rhetoric on more cases. The VHP is extending its support to the petitioners. And RSS *prachar pramukh* Sunil Ambekar told INDIA TODAY: "We should let the truth come out. It's time we put historical facts in the right perspective before society." But both RSS and VHP leaders say neither they nor their affiliates take up legal issues directly.

The menu of tactical choices on the chessboard doesn't end there. By citing the courts *and* the Constitution, the BJP has left the door ajar for an amendment to the Places of Worship Act should it feel the court battles are not going its way. With the 2024 general election not too far on the horizon, it will be fairly easy to bring a simmering Mandir Wapsi movement to boil and scald any discontent over unemployment and inflation arising from a stalling economy. Of course, there's the small matter of proving the historicity of the relic found at Gyanvapi—so far a mere piece of videographic evidence, leaked to the media before being shown in court or verified by experts for authenticity. Is it indeed a historical religious relic or just an architectural accessory?

Facts are sacred too. The new revivalism, though, speaks of placing faith above all. Not an inward-bound faith: it finds its focus in locating an enemy, in wiping out all remnants of what it sees as 'oppressive Muslim tyrants'. And it sees them everywhere: from an emperor's monument to a dirt-poor shanty. It's what psychiatrists call the scapegoat mechanism—a defensive aggression where you respond to life's crises by "spontaneously blaming arbitrarily selected groups or individuals"—fostered by the illusion that the Hindu is an innocent victim of history. For now, the shroud of question marks the freelance stormtroopers have cast is darkening the air, leaving its soot even on the Qutub Minar and the Taj, among India's prized contributions to humanity's built heritage and the history of beauty. There's another edifice in the picture—the Constitution, the document that's also a monument. ■

–with Kaushik Deka and Anilesh S. Mahajan

